

Rebecca Pizzitola

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Education

Stanford University

Conferring June 14, 2026

B.S. Symbolic Systems, concentration in Human-Computer Interaction

M.A. Linguistics, thesis: "What Is 'Depressed Speech'? Investigating Response Time in Major Depressive Disorder Through Indexicality Theory"

Advising and Leadership Experience

Advising Fellow, Symbolic Systems Department — Stanford University

Sept 2025 - Jun 2026

- Declare students as SymSys majors or minors
- Advise on choice in concentration advisor, study abroad, career choices, uncertainties about the department, and other confusions
- Edit and publish the department's biweekly newsletter

Peer Advisor, Department of French and Italian — Stanford University

Jan 2025 - Jun 2025

- Declared students as majors or minors in Italian or French
- Advised students on study abroad experiences, language learning opportunities, course choices, professor relationships, etc
- Maintained a presence in the DLCL community

Resident Assistant (RA) — Stanford University

Sept 2022 - Jun 2024

- Supervised a group of 110 Stanford freshmen living in Lantana House with a team of 5 other RAs
- Responded to high-stress situations, such as mental health crises, roommate conflicts, etc.
- Facilitated conversations with first responders and Stanford faculty and admin as needed
- Organized over 15 events per year with budgets ranging from \$100 to \$10,000 to provide unique, accessible, and substance-free programming for residents
- Promoted diversity, equity, and inclusion in the dorm and residential community
- Managed multiple budgets, totaling over \$55,000 and verify credit card transactions weekly, ensuring correct itemization and distribution of funds

[^] *Residential Leader Student Advisory (RSLA) Board Member*

Sept 2023 - Jun 2024

- Selected among 500+ Stanford RAs to be a member of the advisory board
 - Attended monthly meetings with Orlando White, former Associate Director of Residential Education, with a group of 20 other RAs to discuss issues and concerns related to resident life
 - Traveled to regional and national student leader conferences to learn novel ideas from peer institutions to be implemented at Stanford
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Research Experience

Research Assistant, Language and Cognition Lab — Stanford University

Summer 2024

- Recruited 30 pairs of children aged 4 and 5 at Bing Nursery School to participate in an experiment, designed as a game for their cooperation
- Managed behavioral issues ad hoc during experiments to ensure each trial runs smoothly without compromising data

- Analyzed data in R, determining whether or not children can invent, communally understand, and remember novel words to describe novel abstract photos, as adults have been shown to do in adult versions of this experiment

Research Assistant, Dr Craig Heller's Lab — Stanford University

Nov 2022 - Mar 2025

- Participated in the daily care of over 100 lab mice, feeding them and changing their cages weekly
- Examined the behavioral and physiological differences in mice with Down Syndrome before and after being treated with pentylenetetrazole
- Taught junior undergraduates lab procedures, basic neurobiology, and how to read and present academic research
- Awarded the Wu Tsai Neurosciences Institute Undergraduate Research Fellowship in Summer 2023

Bio-X Undergraduate Research Program — Stanford University

Summer 2022

- Researched under the supervision of Pediatric Neurosurgeon Dr Laura Prolo and Stanford University School of Medicine Student Gaby Ruiz Colon, AB
- Analyzed, using Stata, the differences in communication patterns between Spanish-speaking caregivers and English-speaking caregivers of children being treated for hydrocephalus
- Created and presented a poster summarizing my findings with figures modeling the data I collected
- Co-authored the corresponding paper, which won the John Hanbery award for best neuroscience paper in 2023, and has since been published in the Journal of Pediatrics

Publications, Posters, and Presentations

Yannick Mofor, Rebecca Pizzitola, Veronica Boyce, Bobby Sparks, Michael Frank. Investigating Children's Ability to Use Ad Hoc Referential Expressions (Poster Presentation, Symbolic Systems Fall Poster Fair, September 2024, Stanford, CA)

E C Pittaras, J M Artal, G Ajibola, G Allocca, M Bennett, A Camargo, A Carpio, N Gessner, M Hinton, R Pizzitola, N Tan, E Zhang, A Zhong, H C Heller, Short term GABA antagonist treatment improves long term sleep quality, memory, and decision-making in a Down syndrome mouse model, *Sleep*, 2024;,, zsae300, <https://doi.org/101093/sleep/zsae300>

Akshay Swaminathan et al, Extraction of Unstructured Electronic Health Records to Evaluate Glioblastoma Treatment Patterns *JCO Clin Cancer Inform* 8, e2300091 (2024) doi: 101200/CCI2300091

Rebecca Pizzitola, Grace Abijola, Angelica Alvarado Carpio, Elsa Pittaras, Craig Heller. Cognitive Effects of Pentelynetetrazol in a Mouse Model of Down's Syndrome (Poster Presentation, Wu Tsai Neurosciences Institute Poster Session, August 2023, Stanford, CA)

Ruiz Colón GD, Pizzitola RJ, Grant GA, Prolo LM. Disparities in Postoperative Communication Patterns Among Spanish-Speaking Pediatric Patients with Hydrocephalus, *The Journal of Pediatrics* (2023), doi: <https://doi.org/101016/jjpeds2023113678>

Ruiz Colón G, Pizzitola R, Grant G, Prolo L. Language as a Driver of Outcomes in Pediatric Patients with Hydrocephalus (Oral Presentation, San Francisco Neurological Society Annual Meeting, March 2023, Napa Valley, CA)

Ruiz Colón G, Pizzitola R, Grant G, Prolo L. Hydrocephalus Outcomes in Children Among Spanish Speaking Patients at a Single Institution (Oral Presentation, AANS/CNS Pediatrics Section Annual Meeting, December 2022, Washington DC)

Rebecca J. Pizzitola, Gabriela D. Ruiz Colon, Gerald A. Grant MD FACS, Laura M. Prolo MD PhD.
Hydrocephalus Outcomes Among Spanish Speaking Patients at a Single Institution (Poster Presentation, Bio-X Undergraduate Research Poster Fair, August 2022, Stanford, CA)

Engineering and Technology

User Experience Researcher — Autograph.ai, San Francisco, CA Jan 2026 - Present

- Conduct ~5 weekly teardown-style user interviews to diagnose usability issues and uncover friction points in an early-stage product
- Synthesize qualitative feedback into clear, actionable tickets for engineers, spanning bug fixes, UX improvements, and feature refinements
- Partner closely with founders and developers to prioritize research-driven product iterations
- Build and manage a “Pioneers Program” of trusted early users, maintaining ongoing relationships to support rapid feedback cycles
- Design and facilitate user workshops to test features, validate use cases, and assess product-market fit
- Contribute to product direction by identifying emerging use cases and translating user insights into roadmap recommendations

UX Engineering Intern — Pinterest, San Francisco, CA Summer 2025

- Built a TypeScript/Nodejs automation pipeline using the Figma REST API to streamline design-to-engineering handoff tracking across all product design teams
- Designed recursive parsing logic to detect checklist compliance, extract scores/timestamps, and generate CSV reports consumed by design leadership
- Reduced monthly manual effort from 10 hours across 20 PMs to 10 minutes by one employee, dramatically improving team efficiency and visibility
- Gained experience working with PMs, designers, and engineers to identify workflow bottlenecks and deliver an impactful internal tool

Web Development Intern — UCSF, San Francisco, CA February 2024 - December 2024

- Developed a website for Dr Renee Hsia’s lab at UCSF, compiling publications, media, articles, and Op-Eds for dissemination to the general population
- Conducted user experience research to ensure that Dr Hsia’s publications and other lab content is accessible to all readers regardless of medical knowledge

Data Intern — The Living Tongues Institute, remote May 2024

- Extracted and processed over 300 entries of conative animal calls in 21 languages from various publications of language studies for use in Living Dictionaries and in research by Dr Alexander Andrason at the University of Cape Town
 - Organized over 1520 total entries by language, lexical item, ISO code, orthographic lemmas, and IPA transcriptions
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Other Skills

Languages: English (native), Italian (working proficiency)

Programming Languages: C++, Javascript, Python, React, NodeJS, Typescript

Other technical skills: GitHub

Design: Figma, Adobe InDesign, Adobe After Effects, iMovie, Drupal

Data analysis: Excel, Google Sheets, Stata, R

Research: Quantitative methods, qualitative methods, intertextuality, case study